



OCEAN PIONEERS

The first people to venture far from shore were not interested in the oceans themselves, but in the lands that might lie beyond them. Some of the earliest navigators were people who were seeking new places to live, like the Polynesians who were settling on many of the Pacific islands some 2,000 years ago. Later explorers were motivated by trade and plunder, but by then people were already exploring the oceans for their own sake, to map them and discover their secrets.

▲ ANCIENT MARINERS

The earliest ocean explorers may have been native Australians, who crossed the Timor Sea from Indonesia more than 50,000 years ago. About 3,500 years ago, the Polynesians set out from the western fringes of the Pacific to spread slowly across the biggest ocean on Earth. More than 1,000 years ago, the Vikings were probing west across the Atlantic in their sailing ships, as seen here in this Viking carving, reaching America 500 years before Christopher Columbus (1451–1506).



◀ ORIENTAL FLEETS

The Chinese admiral Zheng He (1371–1433) was one of the first explorers of the Indian Ocean. He made seven voyages in the early 1400s, visiting India, Arabia, and eastern Africa. He commanded a huge fleet of more than 300 ships, including a giant nine-masted vessel that was five times the size of the ship in which Columbus crossed the Atlantic in 1492.

pioneers

FERDINAND MAGELLAN ►

The first round-the-world voyage was accidental. In 1519, Ferdinand Magellan (1480–1521) headed west across the Atlantic and Pacific to reach the Indonesian Spice Islands without crossing the Indian Ocean, which was controlled by the Portuguese. He meant to come back the same way, but when he was killed in a fight his crew decided to keep sailing west, across the Indian Ocean and back into the Atlantic. Of the 265 men who set out on the voyage, just 18 returned.

